

Jaiswal's fluidity and Kohli's sheer class. Strangely, the Australian media goes sniffing around for a split within the home team, pitting bowlers against batters, but skipper Pat Cummins counters, "We are a tight unit."

The vibe Down Under

Perth on the western coast has a time zone allied with Singapore, and that helps both the players and the travelling bandwagon of cricket writers adjust their body clocks. It is also a city that tends to get into snooze mode early as convenience stores wind up by 7 p.m. except for a few corporate ones. The people, like in the rest of Australia, are warm and to the point. Most are busy in perpetual motion, either heading to work, out on a jog, or walking the dog.

The houseflies out here act too familiar, often hovering around faces, and most sports writers develop a reflexive twitch as they try to dissuade these intruders. At Perth's Optus Stadium, a security guard accidentally swallows a fly, a cough ensues, water is quaffed, spittle is ejected, and hopefully the unpalatable nutrient was thrown out.

The cab drivers

Itesham, a Pakistani cab driver in Perth, is clued into issues, both sporting and political, on either side of the Wagah border. "We are all one; just ignore the politicians," he keeps repeating. A fan of Kohli, he admits to a grudging admiration for Bumrah too. The latter surely has taken Australia by storm, and a lot of prose is indulged in on his hyper-extension in the final delivery stride.

Another cab driver from Vietnam is all excitement and a barrage of words. "It is just 150 Australian dollars by flight to home. Perth has a lot of money as there is mining around this city," Minh says, and then adds, "I don't follow cricket, but good luck to all of you."

It is a small world too, as in Canberra, one of the cab drivers is Amit. It turns out he is related to Neeraj Chopra, who had attended his wedding back home too. Talk veers towards athletics, wrestling



and volleyball. Surely, there is more to sport than just cricket, a game invented by the British and owned by the Indians!

Capital tales

Canberra, with its tree-lined avenues and laidback feel, lacks the buzz associated with traditional capitals. But it has history shimmering at every turn. Old churches and pubs that do a hat-tip to a past when settlers trooped in with their own quirks all add to the charm. Its cricket venue, the Manuka Oval, is another blast-from-the-past ground.

With a seating capacity just about adequate and stands named after Sir Donald Bradman, this is an outpost that is pastoral and a throwback to an amateur era. Rohit Sharma's men limber up, and they do feel at ease as they walk back towards their hotel.

Owning Down Under: The local papers in Perth embrace the Indian vernacular while doing supplements on Virat Kohli. TWITTER | RAVISHASTRI

An activity they can never do in India.

For the media, it is time to adjust their body clocks again. At five and a half hours ahead of India, there is ample time to file copies, and yet this dissonance is unsettling. The harking back to the good old days is a theme that even radiates from a pub on Friday night as Mambo No. 5 is belted out and youngsters jive. The rains, though, throw a damp curtain, and questions linger about the prospects of the game between the Prime Minister's XI and India under lights at the Manuka Oval. Perhaps the weather gods would be kind as November winds to a close.